attended each other's training academies, and the two General Staffs met regularly.[33]

India and the US as 'natural allies'

As the differences between China and the US sharpened and the power gap between them shrank, India and the US looked to build a strategic partnership. In September 1998, hoping to repair ties with the US after the nuclear tests, Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee publicly averred that 'India and the United States are natural allies in the quest for a better future for the world in the 21st century' – the first time an Indian leader had used the word 'ally' in the same breath as 'India and the United States'.[34]

Pakistan's military ingress into Kargil May–July 1999 only served to bring Delhi and Washington closer. Given the possibility of the conflict escalating to the nuclear level, Washington intervened to get Pakistani troops to withdraw. Terrorists attacked the Kashmir legislature in October 2001, just weeks after the events of 9/11, and then followed with an attack on India's Parliament in December 2001. In response, India mobilized its forces, threatening to go to war against Pakistan. Again, and for similar reasons, Washington stepped in, leaning on President Pervez Musharraf to rein in terrorist groups operating in Pakistan. Musharraf's televised address to his country mollified India enough for Vajpayee to call off Operation Parakram, the full-scale military mobilization on the India–Pakistan border.

When President Clinton addressed the Indian Parliament in March 2000, he endorsed Vajpayee's words on the strategic affinity between India and the US. The phrase passed into the lexicon of India–US diplomacy, and with variations – natural friends, strategic partners, critical allies – it has stayed there. The word 'natural' suggested that the two countries were not allies in the formal sense, obliged to come to each other's defence against a common enemy. Being 'natural' allies, they were bonded by something deeper, almost metaphysical, by common values or a shared worldview.